Marketplace sourcing options for APEX-EFN

Wallapop, Vinted and Alibaba reviewed · recommendation for D5-11 · 11 November 2026

Neither of the two candidates can be automated for what APEX-EFN does. That is a finding, not a blocker: every mainstream marketplace forbids scraping, and the compliant routes are official APIs, partner agreements and price feeds.

Platform	Scraping	Bot chat / negotiation	Fit for B2B volume
Vinted	**Forbidden**	**Explicitly forbidden**	Weak: C2C second-hand, personal use only
Alibaba	**Forbidden without written permission**	Not in the terms; official API / partner route exists	**Good: B2B wholesale**
Wallapop (decided)	**Forbidden**	**Forbidden**	Weak: C2C second-hand

Vinted: the worst of the three

Terms and conditions, section 6 (“You must not”), version applicable 08-10-2026:

> *“use any kind of external software tools (including but not limited to: **bots, scraping programs, crawling programs, spiders**) when registering on the Site and/or when using the Site and/or Services … unless such a use is authorised, offered or in any other way allowed by us” — and “data mine, screen scrape, crawl, disassemble, decompile or reverse engineer any part of the Site”.*

Their robots.txt is even more explicit, with a transactional section:

> *“Automated agents, bots, or AI systems are **NOT permitted** to: create/register accounts, add items to carts, make purchases, perform checkouts/payments, or **engage in any activity that simulates a customer interaction**.”*

Our negotiation is a simulated customer interaction by definition. On top of that: private messages are for item information only, “unsolicited or mass messages sent to 5 or more members are not allowed”, one personal account, personal use unless Vinted Pro — and it is a C2C second-hand marketplace, the wrong shape for buying thousands of units.

Alibaba: right shape, wrong door

Terms of use, clause 3.2:

> *“Systematic retrieval of Site Content from the Sites to create or compile, directly or indirectly, a collection, compilation, database or directory (whether through **robots, spiders, automatic devices or manual processes**) without written permission from Alibaba.com is prohibited.”*

Its robots.txt is more permissive than Vinted's (`/product-detail/`, `/showroom/`, `/catalog/*?` are allowed), but the terms govern: collecting a catalogue systematically needs written permission.

The good news is that Alibaba has the sanctioned door: an official developer platform (open.alibaba.com), supplier and affiliate programmes, and the B2B vocabulary the product needs — MOQ, volume tiers, RFQ, Trade Manager chat. That is business development, not a coding task.

The pattern worth internalising

Every mainstream marketplace bans scraping. The only sanctioned routes are:

1. **Official API** — eBay Browse, Etsy OAuth, Bol, Amazon PA-API, Alibaba Open Platform.
2. **Partner or affiliate agreement** — the “unless authorised by us” carve-out that Wallapop's and Vinted's terms point at.

3. **Feeds** for price data — Google Merchant, idealo. This is also the cleanest source for the price-sanity benchmark D3-07 needs, and it involves no scraping at all.

What actually fits our product

The one platform found where programmatic negotiation is an official API is **Mercado Libre**:

```
POST /questions → ask a seller a question on an item GET /questions/search → read the
thread for an item GET /items → search listings and read seller reputation
```

It is an authorised, documented, rate-limited channel — not a bot behind a login. They also expose "pre-negotiated per item and full stock sale" endpoints for volume deals.

Caveat, stated plainly: using Q&A to negotiate price at volume may still conflict with marketplace rules about deals struck outside their mechanics — which is exactly what their pre-negotiated offers API exists to avoid. Their developer terms must be read closely before building on it.

Recommendation

1. **Alibaba via partner / Open Platform** — best product fit; needs a business request first, then the adapter. Slowest to unblock, highest value.
2. **Mercado Libre official API** — fastest to real, sanctioned negotiation; weaker B2B volume fit, and its own terms caveat.
3. **Feeds only** (Google / idealo) — unblocks the sanity engine's benchmark legally with no marketplace at all. Worth doing regardless.
4. **Stay on the mocks** and leave `negotiation.autonomous_send` inert until one of the above exists.

> *This is not legal advice. Anything under "written consent" needs a signature, not a code change; the compliance doc and ADR are written before the adapter, as with Wallapop (ADR-506).*